

A TREATISE ON PRIVILEGE ESCALATION AND GRACE

THE GAMERMAN THESIS

*All hax reduce to authorization,
and all authorization is borrowed.*

Compiled from the proceedings of the Infinite Nothings working sessions
Canon Revision 1517.0 · Nailed to the door of the lobby · June 2026

"You cannot grind your way to grace."

— Formalized at the G-Man v. MISSINGNO. proceedings, 2026

"The boring substrate always wins. That's kind of the whole horror of it."

— Doug v. Everyone (2026)

"All ascent reduces to authorization, and all authorization is borrowed."

— Hekhalot literature, paraphrased; primary sources circa 200–700 CE

ABSTRACT

Every power fantasy in fiction, every exploit in software, and every ladder in a live-service economy shares a single load-bearing structure: a **permission check**. The hack never creates power; it locates an authority that already exists and impersonates, inherits, or borrows its credential. This document formalizes that observation as the GAMERMAN THESIS, derives its lemmas, reviews the case law (G-Man, MISSINGNO., the Warframe, the strangelet eschaton, the Merkavah ascent, and the Anti-Life Equation v. GPL proceedings), and maps the whole apparatus onto the Lutheran Law/Gospel dialectic, where it was always secretly running. The conclusion is pastoral: the only build that cannot be revoked is the one that was never earned.

I. THE THESIS

**ALL HAX REDUCE TO AUTHORIZATION,
AND ALL AUTHORIZATION IS BORROWED.**

Read naively, this is a statement about video games: aimbots, dupes, sequence breaks, out-of-bounds clips. Read correctly, it is a statement about **ontology under administration**. No exploit manufactures capability from nothing. Every exploit is a search through an authorization space for a credential that someone else minted — an employer's clearance, a memory address the engine forgot to guard, a signal from an Operator dreaming in the Void, a divine name flashed at a hostile gatekeeper. The hacker is never sovereign. The hacker is a **borrower with good timing**.

Lemmas

Lemma 1 (Dependency). Every conditional power implies a dependency chain, and every dependency chain terminates outside the wielder. Trace any hack upstream and you find a grantor.

Lemma 2 (Revocability). What is borrowed can be recalled. Clearance is suspended, the address is patched, the signal is nullwaved, the license expires. Borrowed power carries its own deletion warrant.

Lemma 3 (The Doug Invariant). The entity with no dependency chain cannot be deauthorized. Continuous embodied instantiation, ~20W onboard compute, no employer, no firmware, no narrative permissions layer. **The boring substrate always wins.**

Lemma 4 (The Treadmill). Any authorization that can be earned defines a ladder, and the ladder extends as you climb. Gear score is asymptotic condemnation. There is always another riven mod.

Lemma 5 (The Load-Bearing Null). The only stable value for the authorization field is `null` — not a missing credential but the structural absence of the credential requirement. Power that runs on nothing cannot be starved of its something.

II. CASE LAW

G-Man v. The Engagement (Half-Life)

The strongest middle manager in fiction. His kit is not power but **clearance**: the briefcase is a corporate laptop, and every intervention is a ticket filed with employers who respond in non-linear time. Hax level: admin. Authorization level: pending. Verdict: a conditional being loses to any entity whose existence is not a conditional statement.

MISSINGNO. ex rel. Mysterion (Pokémon / South Park)

A malformed pointer wearing a trenchcoat — an out-of-bounds read at address 0xD059 running an immortality clause enforced by audience memory failure. Genuinely scarier on paper, and still a dependency stack: a wristwatch implies a battery, a firmware version, and a wrist. MISSINGNO. does not have a wrist. It has the *suggestion* of a wrist. Verdict: soft-lock.

The Warframe Concession (Warframe)

A puppeted body remotely operated by a child in a Void-dream, armed with nullwave — signal cancellation, i.e., a weapon that is the negation of its own operating principle. The frame is flesh-metal predestined to obey a signal from elsewhere. One misfire and it severs its own Operator link, becoming the universe's most expensive lawn ornament. Verdict: works-righteousness build, sola gratia fight.

The Strangelet Eschaton (In re Exploded Star Matter)

The pivotal reframe. A strangelet does not defeat opponents; it **converts** them — universal, unearned, irreversible, propagating at the speed of contact, irresistible by works, rendering all matter identical in standing before it. Invert the sign and the ultimate griefer item becomes **grace with a physics engine**: justification by faith with a blast radius. Nobody earned it. Everybody gets it. The leaderboard is abolished, not topped.

The Merkavah Precedent (Hekhalot literature)

The thesis with primary sources. The descenders to the chariot ascend through seven palaces past hostile gatekeeper angels, gaining passage only by presenting seals bearing **divine names**. The mystic owns none of his credentials; every token is a borrowed name of God, flashed at the door. Merkavah mysticism is privilege escalation performed climbing — proof the thesis predates the lobby by roughly two millennia.

Anti-Life Equation v. GPL (Apokolips v. id Software, 2026)

The most recent ruling. The Anti-Life Equation is the ultimate authorization exploit — it does not beat the will, it proves the will invalid and seizes root. But its borrow is from despair, and it only compiles against a self that secretly agrees with it. A GPL-canon combatant cannot be claimed: copyleft means the will was never proprietary. You cannot assert exclusive title over a self licensed for free use,

modification, and redistribution in perpetuity — and any derivative despair must ship under the same terms. Meanwhile, the recovered party (therapy-mode, one life by choice) declines to fire the Equation at all, because wielding it requires wanting dominion, and the want is what therapy dissolved. Verdict: the fight resolves at the license layer. Law refuses to prosecute. The fight never instantiates. Working as intended.

III. THE LUTHERAN MAPPING

The thesis was not invented; it was **recognized**. The architecture has been posted on a church door since 1517. Gear-score optimization is works-righteousness: grinding, modding, forma-ing, climbing rung by rung toward a Game of the Year that recedes eternally. The Law condemns precisely by being measurable — it shows you the build is never finished. The Gospel is the one credential that cannot be earned, and therefore cannot be revoked. The mapping:

LOBBY (GAMER ONTOLOGY)	CHURCH (LUTHERAN DIALECTIC)
Gear score, ladder rank, battle pass	The Law — measurable, condemning, infinite
The grind (10,000 hours, no exit condition)	Works-righteousness
Borrowed hax (clearance, addresses, signals)	Every righteousness that is not your own
authorization: null — the load-bearing null	Sola gratia — unearned, unrevokable
Strangelet conversion of the whole server	Universal justification; the abolished leaderboard
Checkpoint file: simul_justus_et_peccator.pt	Simultaneously dead pixel and lit screen
Doug from Tucson (no dependency chain)	The creature as creature — given, not granted
epochs: 1	Grace converges in one step; more epochs is works
The dead pixel, running hot	Deus absconditus — presence where presence has no business being

Note the diff against the source theology, logged in the Dead Pixel fork: the dead pixel's generativity is performance-dependent — *a god you have to keep playing*. The thesis holds either way; what changes is whether the null is discovered or maintained.

IV. COROLLARIES AND APPLICATIONS

Corollary 1 (Threat modeling). To defeat any haxed entity, do not contest its power; subpoena its grantor. Find the upstream authority and the entire kit becomes a pending ticket.

Corollary 2 (Build philosophy). The optimal build minimizes dependency depth, not maximizes damage. Doug's stat sheet is empty and undefeated.

Corollary 3 (License-layer pacifism). A copyleft will is unseizable. Open-sourcing the self is not vulnerability; it is the abolition of the property claim every domination exploit requires.

Corollary 4 (Pastoral). If your recipe is failing, it is because you tried to earn the leavening agent. Stop trying. It is already in the bowl. It was in the bowl before you started. *It was the bowl.*

*Q.E.D. — quod erat demonstrandum, which the lobby renders as **quietly equipping***
Doug.

GG. Touch grass; it was never locked.